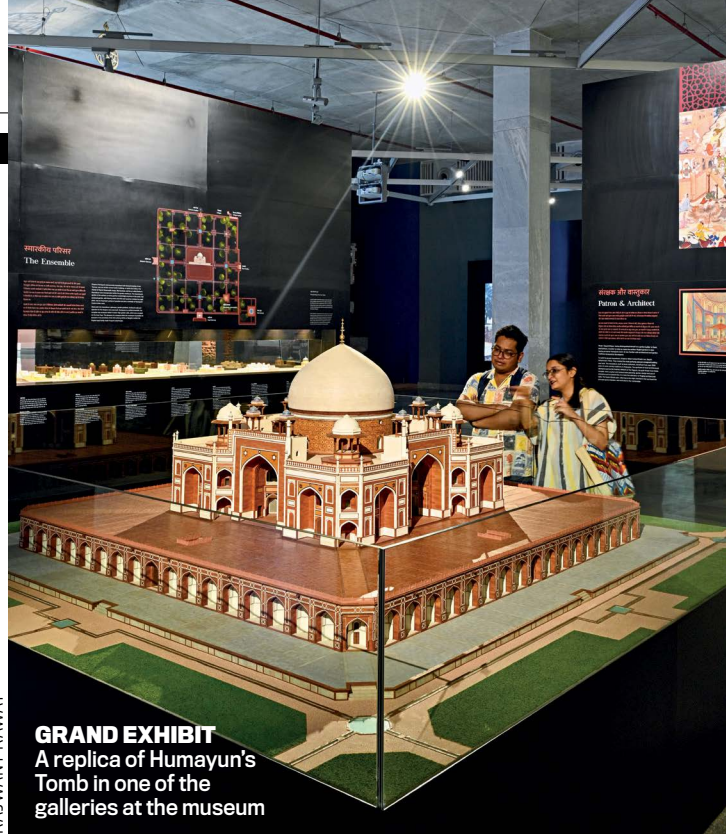


RAJWANT RAWAT

GRAND EXHIBIT
A replica of Humayun's Tomb in one of the galleries at the museum

The Humayun Tomb World Heritage Site Museum—to give it its proper name—has been in the making for nearly a decade, but restoration and urban renewal initiatives in the 300-acre Nizamuddin Conservation Area, of which Humayun's Tomb is a part, have been ongoing for 25 years. The museum is the crowning glory of that grand project, which has given us—apart from a resplendent Humayun's Tomb—Sunder Nursery and its historical monuments, a restored Sabz Burj—which historian Ebba Koch has surmised is the tomb of Humayun's mother, Maham Begum—and community affirming projects in Hazrat Nizamuddin Basti.

The creation of the site museum—set in the entrance zone of the Humayun's Tomb Complex and the Sunder Nursery heritage park—was spearheaded by the Aga Khan Trust for Culture (AKTC) in partnership with the Archaeological Survey of India (ASI), all under the watchful eye of conservation architect Ratish Nanda, who heads AKTC in India. Designed by Vir.Mueller Architects, the museum complex spans an area of 10,000 square metres, and is mostly underground to comply with the 1.2m height restriction around protected monuments, leaving the vista of the tomb unsullied.

Clad in red sandstone, the facilities building is above ground, on the Sunder Nursery side. It already houses a 100-seater auditorium in its basement and will have restaurants and souvenir shops by the end of the year. The museum also provides underground passage between Humayun's Tomb and Sunder Nursery, otherwise separated by a road. The goal of the state-of-the-art facility is "to inform visitors of the cultural context and the extent of the UNESCO World Heritage Site". "This is a museum that tells stories," says Nanda.

WITH OVER 700 ARTEFACTS ON DISPLAY ACROSS THREE GALLERIES, THE MUSEUM SEEMS QUITE THE EMBARRASSMENT OF RICHES

The tales are told across three permanent galleries. While the first gallery highlights the 12 monuments in the tomb's vicinity, the principal second gallery—called 'Where the Emperor Rests'—focuses on Humayun's Tomb, its architectural significance and conservation through architectural models, replicas of architectural elements and original artefacts. The third gallery, 'Icons of a Sacred Landscape', showcases important personalities associated with the Nizamuddin area, including the 14th-century Sufi saint Nizamuddin Auliya; his disciple, the poet Amir Khusrau; the poet Rahim; and Dara Shukoh. There's also a space for temporary exhibitions and they hope to mount the first one later this year.

With over 700 artefacts—including miniatures, coins, manuscripts, weaponry, astrolabes and celestial spheres (Humayun had an abiding interest in planetary astrology), tiles, textiles, and much more—it seems quite the embarrassment of riches. As if that weren't enough, "each artefact you see in this museum has been displayed for the first time ever," says Nanda. The exhibits themselves are striking, the accompanying write-ups pithy (but only a fraction of the available information has been presented; more will soon be added on using QR codes, and some publications are planned as well). There's sagacious use of tech, for instance, in the 270-degree immersive screen which provides a virtual tour of the monuments and plays an animated film showcasing the evolution of the site over 500 years. While the museum belongs to the ASI, many of the exhibits are on loan from the National Museum (for an initial period of 10 years) or from AKTC's collection while several were found in the area during the decades-long conservation project.

The museum has far too many beautiful objects to acknowledge individually, but a few do pop out. Seeing copies of the *Humayun-Nama* and the *Ain-i-Akbari* will give any bibliophile goosebumps. Or take the Mughal helmet on display. Humayun travelled 34,000 kilometres in his lifetime, from Tabriz in the west to Gaur in the east, and this itinerant existence informs a section of the display. A Mughal soldier's helmet here is tied to an anecdote about Humayun cooking horse meat in a helmet to avoid starvation on a perilous jour-